

Martin Heidegger, The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics: World, Finitude, Solitude

GA 29/30 · Freiburg Lecture Course, Winter Semester 1929–30 · trans. McNeill & Walker (Indiana UP, 1995)

The Theory of Boredom (*Die Langeweile*)

Part One, §§16–38, with the Part Two hinge (§39) — and an application to the study of student boredom and psychological engagement in virtual learning environments

Book pp. 59–175 · GA 29/30 pp. 89–260 · PDF pp. 41–99 (2-up scan; book = 2·pdf 24)

Orienting Thesis of the Boredom Analysis

Part One of the 1929–30 lecture course is the longest sustained analysis of a single mood anywhere in Heidegger’s corpus, and its wager is stated before any boredom is described: an attunement (*Stimmung*) is not a psychic state to be *ascertained* but a fundamental way of Da-sein that can only be *awakened* (§16, p. 60 / GA 90 / pdf 42). Boredom (*Langeweile* — literally the “long while”) is selected because, of all attunements, it wears its relation to *time* on its face; and time, Heidegger holds, is the root of the three metaphysical questions the course is pledged to — world, finitude, individuation (§20, p. 81 / GA 121–22 / pdf 52). The analysis then descends through three forms, each deeper than the last, each re-running the same structural machinery: *becoming bored by something* (*Gelangweiltwerden von etwas*), *being bored with something* (*Sichlangweilen bei etwas*), and profound boredom, the impersonal *es ist einem langweilig* (“it is boring for one”). Every form is built from two structural moments — being left empty (*Leergelassenheit*) and being held in limbo (*Hingehaltenheit*) — and a counter-move, passing the time (*Zeitvertreib*), whose changing physiognomy across the three forms is the analysis’s principal diagnostic. The descent terminates in the claim that what bores is “neither beings nor things as such ... neither objects nor subjects, but temporality as such” (§35, p. 158 / GA 236 / pdf 90), and profound boredom, pressed to its ground, *gives to be questioned* the three metaphysical questions themselves (§39, p. 169 / GA 252–53 / pdf 96). Boredom is thus not a deficit of stimulation but a mode of disclosure with a temporal signature: its measure is never “how unengaged,” but *what, and how, it makes manifest*.

Citation and provenance discipline. Loci are given as a triple (p. NN / GA NN / pdf NN): English pagination of the McNeill & Walker translation, the Gesamtausgabe (Klostermann) bracket pagination as printed in the running heads (it drifts non-linearly against the English and is never computed), and the page of the 2-up PDF scan in corpus/metaphysics/. Two registers are kept strictly apart throughout: faithful exposition of Heidegger’s text (Parts I–III of this report), and projected application (Part IV), where FCM’s categories are brought to the King–Salvo virtual-learning-environment studies. Every projected mapping is a hypothesis of this report — neither Heidegger’s claim nor the empirical authors’ — and is flagged as such.

Part I. The Method: Attunement Must Be Awakened, Not Ascertained (§§16–18)

§16. Awakening as letting-be; the failure of the conscious/unconscious schema

pp. 59–65 / GA 89–99 / pdf 41–44

Heidegger opens by blocking the obvious method. Attunements are “something we can least of all invent, something that comes over us,” something “into which we slip unawares” (p. 59 / GA 90 / pdf 41). They can therefore neither be manufactured nor demonstrated: “any so-called objective ascertaining of a fundamental attunement is a dubious, indeed impossible undertaking” (p. 60 / GA 90 / pdf 42). The failure is not merely epistemic — it is no objection that a hearer, observing himself, fails to find the attunement, “for in the end there is nothing at all to be found by observation ... even if it were to call upon psychoanalysis for help” (p. 60 / GA 90 / pdf 42). Hence the pivot that governs the whole book:

“We shall not speak at all of ‘ascertaining’ a fundamental attunement in our philosophizing, but of *awakening* it. ... Awakening means making something wakeful, letting whatever is sleeping become wakeful.” (p. 60 / GA 90 / pdf 42)

Whatever sleeps is “in a peculiar way absent and yet there” (p. 60 / GA 91 / pdf 42) — and Heidegger refuses to resolve this into *conscious* versus *unconscious*. Sleep is not absence of consciousness (dreams are “a peculiar and in many cases extremely animated consciousness,” p. 61–62 / GA 93–94 / pdf 42–43), and — the load-bearing methodological claim — making an attunement into “an object of knowledge” achieves “the contrary of an awakening”: the attunement is “thereby precisely destroyed, or at least ... weakened and altered” (p. 62 / GA 93–94 / pdf 43). The ontological alternative to the consciousness-schema is the pair being-there / being-away (*Da-sein* / *Weg-sein*): in conversation we are often “not there” without being asleep, and this absence “can be highly conscious” (p. 63 / GA 94–96 / pdf 43). Being-away is not the opposite of being-there but presupposes it: “The stone, in its being away, is precisely not there. Man however must be there in order to be able to be away” (p. 64 / GA 96–97 / pdf 44).

§17. Attunement as a fundamental way of Dasein — and the power of the unnoticed

pp. 66–68 / GA 99–103 / pdf 45–46

The positive counter-thesis is won from the phenomenology of shared grief: when a person we are with is overcome by grief, “everything remains as before, and yet everything is different ... the way in which we are together is different” (p. 66 / GA 99–100 / pdf 45). The attunement “is not at all inside, in some sort of soul of the Other,” nor outside; it “imposes itself on everything” (p. 66–67 / GA 100–101 / pdf 45). Attunements are “like an atmosphere in which we first immerse ourselves ... and which then attunes us through and through” (p. 67 / GA 100–101 / pdf 45). Therefore: “we must dismiss the psychology of feelings, experiences, and consciousness” (p. 67 / GA 100–101 / pdf 45). Attunements are not the fleeting adornment of thinking and willing but “the presupposition for such things, the ‘medium’ within which they first happen” (p. 68 / GA 101–03 / pdf 46).

Two claims from this section carry the entire boredom analysis. First: “Dasein as Dasein is always already attuned in its very grounds. There is only ever a change of attunement” (p. 68 / GA 101–03 / pdf 46) — the

apparent “lack of attunement” of the everyday neither/nor is itself an attunement. Second, the principle of concealment:

“Those attunements to which we pay no heed at all, the attunements we least observe ... as though there is no attunement there at all ... these attunements are *the most powerful*.” (p. 68 / GA 101-03 / pdf 46)

This concealment-of-the-pervasive is the exact structural reason a *profound* boredom can be operative and unnoticed — the possibility on which everything that follows depends.

§18. The contemporary situation; the first naming of profound boredom

pp. 69–77 / GA 103–16 / pdf 46–50

Which attunement, in whose situation? Heidegger surveys four fashionable diagnoses of the age — Spengler’s decline of the West, Klages’s repudiation of spirit, Scheler’s balance of life and spirit, Ziegler’s new Middle Ages — and traces all four to “a particular reception of Nietzsche’s philosophy” and its Dionysian/Apollonian opposition (p. 72 / GA 107–09 / pdf 48). His interest is not their correctness (“We are not even asking whether all these interpretations of our situation are correct or not,” p. 74 / GA 110–11 / pdf 49) but their *function*: cultural diagnosis is “something sensational” that yields “an unconceded, yet once again illusory appeasement” (p. 75 / GA 111–13 / pdf 49). Diagnoses and prognoses “do not involve us, they do not attack us ... they release us from ourselves and present us to ourselves in a world-historical situation and role” (p. 75 / GA 111–13 / pdf 49). The genre “unties us from ourselves,” and in doing so makes “our flight and disorientation, the illusion and our lostness ... more acute” (p. 77 / GA 114–16 / pdf 50).

Then the decisive question, and with it the first appearance of profound boredom in the course — deliberately interrogative, naming a *concealed* attunement:

“Perhaps because we ourselves have become bored with ourselves? ... Do things ultimately stand in such a way with us that a *profound boredom* draws back and forth like a silent fog in the abysses of Dasein?” (p. 77 / GA 114–16 / pdf 50)

The restless need for cultural role-play is thus read as flight from an attunement no one notices — the §17 principle in action. The task of Part One is set: not to prove this boredom is “there,” which is impossible in principle, but to awaken it by descending through its forms.

Part II. The Three Forms of Boredom (§§19–36)

Chapter Two (§§19–23). The first form: becoming bored *by* something

pp. 78–105 / GA 118–59 / pdf 51–64

The reversal of the everyday task, and the strategy of starting from boringness

Boredom, Heidegger insists, “is already awake” — “With open eyes it looks into our Da-sein” (p. 79 / GA 118–19 / pdf 51). Awakening it therefore means “letting it be awake, guarding against it falling asleep” — a “strange or almost insane demand,” since all “natural and sound human comportment” exists precisely “to

pass the time and precisely not to let boredom arise” (p. 79 / GA 118–19 / pdf 51). The translators’ note here is load-bearing: *Langeweile* is literally the “long while,” and the “temporal sense of *Weile* and its stretching” governs everything that follows. Boredom is “a way in which we stand with respect to time, a feeling of time” (p. 80 / GA 119–21 / pdf 51); since time underlies world, finitude, and individuation, boredom “offers an exceptional possibility of answering the three questions” (p. 81 / GA 121–22 / pdf 52).

The analysis deliberately begins “outside”: “We are not really starting from boredom, but from *boringness*” (p. 82 / GA 124–25 / pdf 53) — from the boring book, play, ceremony, place. Three conventional schemata are dismantled in turn: the cause–effect relation (“the book is not the outer cause, nor is the resulting boredom the inner effect,” p. 88 / GA 132–33 / pdf 56); the subject/object property; and transference (the post-Aristotelian “metaphor” doctrine on which we project moods onto things — if the laughing meadow’s cheerfulness “already lies in the things themselves, then ... we are no longer transferring something,” p. 85 / GA 127–29 / pdf 53). What survives the demolition is a proto-definition read off the everyday words “wearisome” and “tedious”:

“Wearisome means: it does not rivet us; we are ... not taken [*hingenommen*] by it, but merely *held in limbo* [*hingehalten*] by it. Tedious means: it does not engross us, we are *left empty* [*leer gelassen*]. ... that which bores, which is boring, is that which holds us in limbo and yet leaves us empty.” (p. 87 / GA 130–32 / pdf 56)

Methodologically, §22 warns against making the attunement “an object swimming in the stream of consciousness which we as observers gaze after” (p. 90 / GA 135–36 / pdf 58); what is needed is “the releasement [*Gelassenheit*] of our free, everyday perspective — free from psychological and other theories of consciousness” (p. 91 / GA 136–38 / pdf 58). And since boredom shows itself precisely where we drive it away, passing-the-time is the access route: “it is precisely in passing the time that we first gain the correct orientation in which we can encounter boredom undisguised” (p. 91 / GA 136–38 / pdf 58).

The train station: Zeitvertreib, the watch, and time that drags

The famous scene: “We are sitting ... in the tasteless station of some lonely minor railway. It is four hours until the next train arrives” (p. 93 / GA 139–41 / pdf 59). We read timetables, count trees, draw figures in the sand, “catch ourselves looking at our watch yet again.” The etymology is unpacked: “Passing the time is a driving away of boredom that *drives time on*” (p. 94 / GA 141–42 / pdf 59; the German footnote gives the formula *Zeitvertreib ist ein Zeit antreibendes Wegtreiben der Langeweile*). Boredom is *not* waiting (“waiting can be full of suspense,” p. 94), not impatience, not ill humour: these “may be present and surround boredom, but they never constitute boredom itself” (p. 95 / GA 142–44 / pdf 60).

The repeated glance at the watch receives a precise diagnostic reading: it “is not itself a passing the time ... but only a sign that we want to pass the time, or more precisely that our passing the time is *not really succeeding*” — a “helpless gesture” indexing *increasing* boredom (p. 97 / GA 146–47 / pdf 61). And what we fight in boredom is not slowness or length of clock-time — “the length of time plays no role” — but drag: “not because the progress of time is slow, but because it is *too* slow”; what oppresses is “this peculiar vacillating and dragging of time” (p. 97 / GA 146–47 / pdf 61). Becoming bored is “a peculiar being affected in a paralysing way *by time as it drags* and by time in general” (p. 98 / GA 147–49 / pdf 61).

The two moments and their interweaving

Being held in limbo (§23c): we are held not by “time in general” but by “this particular interval of time that drags between our arrival and the departure of the train” (p. 100 / GA 150–52 / pdf 63); we look away from the clock “toward nothing in particular,” seeking only diversion. Being left empty (§23d): the station, timetable, and trees are all at hand, and precisely so they leave us empty — “we must even say that they leave us empty *precisely because* they are at hand” (p. 102 / GA 153–55 / pdf 63). Emptiness is not absence:

“To leave empty means to be something at hand that offers nothing. ... Being left empty means to be offered nothing by what is at hand.” (p. 103 / GA 155–56 / pdf 63)

The station “refuses itself to us as a station ... because the train that belongs to it has not yet arrived” (p. 103 / GA 155–56 / pdf 63) — a refusal distinct from disappointment, since “where we become disappointed we have nothing more to seek and we withdraw. But here we precisely stay” (p. 104 / GA 156–58 / pdf 64). The two moments are “not simply pieced together, but structurally interwoven,” with limbo “the all-embracing and primarily determinative” moment: “The dragging of time as it were refuses the station the possibility of offering us anything. It *forces* it to leave us empty” (p. 105 / GA 158–59 / pdf 64). The chapter closes on the thesis that opens the rest of the course: “boredom is only possible at all because each thing, as we say, has its time. If each thing did not have its time, then there would be no boredom” (p. 105 / GA 158–59 / pdf 64).

Chapter Three (§§24–28). The second form: being bored *with* something

pp. 106–131 / GA 161–98 / pdf 65–77

The evening invitation and the vanishing of the culprit

Depth, not duration, is the discriminator: we can be more bored “in someone’s company for five minutes than during the whole four hours” at the station; the objective span “is not decisive for the extent and degree or ... for the *depth* of boredom” (p. 108 / GA 163–64 / pdf 66). The second form’s paradigm is deliberately inconspicuous: an evening invitation. “There we find the usual food and the usual table conversation,” all “not only very tasty, but tasteful as well”; lively discussion, music, wit. “There is nothing at all to be found that might have been boring about this evening.” We come home satisfied — and only then, glancing at the interrupted work, “then it comes: *I was bored after all this evening*” (p. 110 / GA 166–67 / pdf 68). We were not detached observers: “I was totally involved.” Nothing determinate bored us, and yet we were bored — “or perhaps it was precisely the pleasantness of this evening with which we were bored?” (p. 110 / GA 166–67 / pdf 68). Where the first form had “a determinate boring thing,” here the boring “has this character of ‘*I know not what*’” (p. 114 / GA 172–73 / pdf 69).

The transformed Zeitvertreib: the whole evening is the passing-of-time

Searching for the passing-the-time, we at first find only a suppressed yawn and the impulse to drum our fingers. The cigar is the pivotal instance — taken “not to become more sleepy, nor to be stimulated by the nicotine, but because smoking itself is a socially ideal way of passing the time” (p. 112 / GA 169–70 / pdf 68) — yet smoking is no isolated occupation against boredom; while smoking “we precisely participate in the conversation.” The decisive transformation:

“It is not smoking as an isolated occupation, but our *entire comportment and behaviour* that is our passing the time — the whole evening of the invitation itself.” (p. 112 / GA 169–70 / pdf 68)

Boredom and its counter-move have become intertwined and co-extensive: *the surface occupation is the passing-of-time of a boredom it simultaneously conceals*. This is the structural signature of the second form, and the report returns to it in Part IV: outward engagement is here not evidence against boredom but its very medium.

Self-forming emptiness and standing time

Both structural moments seem absent — time does not press (we *gave ourselves* the evening; we never glance at the clock), and the beings do not refuse themselves (“the evening is full”) (p. 115 / GA 173–75 / pdf 69). Both reappear transformed. The emptiness no longer ensues from an unfilled situation; in the casualness (*Lässigkeit*) with which we abandon ourselves to the evening, “any seeking to be satisfied by beings is absent *in advance*,” so the being-left-empty “grows from the depths” (p. 118 / GA 177–79 / pdf 71). The casualness is twofold: abandoning ourselves to what is going on *and* “leaving ourselves behind [*Sichzurücklassen*]” — our proper self. Here “an emptiness precisely first *forms* itself. ... This emptiness is a being left behind of our proper self. This self-forming emptiness is this ‘I know not what’” (p. 120 / GA 180–82 / pdf 72). The evening cannot “satisfy the resolute openness [*Entschlossenheit*] of our whole Dasein” (p. 119 / GA 179–80 / pdf 71).

The limbo, correspondingly, is no longer the drag of an interval. Precisely because we *have* time, we bring the time taken for the evening “to a stand — yet do not cause it to vanish” (p. 121 / GA 182–83 / pdf 73). Fully given over to the present (“entirely present [*ganz Gegenwart*] for what is present,” p. 124 / GA 186–88 / pdf 74), “we are cut off from our having-been and from our future” (p. 125 / GA 188–89 / pdf 75); the now, “sealed off and unbound on both sides ... becomes stuck in its abiding standing, and in its being stuck it stretches itself” — “not several nows ... merely one, a stretched one” (p. 125 / GA 188–89 / pdf 75). And this standing now is not an object over against us: “This standing time — this is *we ourselves* ... our self as that which has been left behind with respect to its provenance and future” (p. 126 / GA 189–91 / pdf 75). Its standing “summons us, it sets us in place” — “then we are bored” (p. 126 / GA 189–91 / pdf 75). The two moments coincide in one structure: the self-forming emptiness *is* the indeterminate, unfamiliar standing now, which “in its self-forming emptiness ... can leave us empty, and in leaving us empty simultaneously *hold us in limbo*” (p. 127 / GA 191–92 / pdf 76). Hence the chapter’s conclusion: “Boredom springs from the temporality of Dasein” (p. 127 / GA 191–92 / pdf 76).

“It arises from out of Dasein itself”; the seven points; the inversion of depth

The keystone contrast with the first form: “in the first case what is boring comes from outside ... But in the second case, what is boring does not come from outside: it arises from out of Dasein itself” (p. 128 / GA 192–94 / pdf 76). The surrounding beings are “only the occasion” of it. Where form I is “an uneasy fidgeting that is directed outward,” form II draws us “into the specific gravity of Dasein” (p. 128 / GA 192–94 / pdf 76). §28 then inverts the surface verdict on seriousness: the first form’s “having no time” — apparently the more serious stance — may be “a *greater being lost of the self*,” enslavement to everyday occupations, while the wasteful having-time of the second form can harbor “a far greater balance and thereby security of Dasein” (p. 130 / GA 195–97 / pdf 77). The lesson generalizes: depth cannot be inferred from the time-relation, from busyness, or from any single surface index — it “can be read off only from the specific constitution of boredom itself in

each case” (p. 130 / GA 195–97 / pdf 77). The chapter closes with a seven-point comparison of the two forms (pp. 130–31 / GA 195–98 / pdf 77) — emptiness at-hand vs. self-forming; detained-by-drag vs. set-in-place-by-standing-time; situation-bound vs. unbound; conspicuous vs. inconspicuous *Zeitvertreib*; fluttering unease vs. letting-oneself-be-bored; forced-in-between vs. floating dissipation; arrival-from-outside vs. arising-from-Dasein — offered not as a result but as a scaffold “for learning and understanding how to move in the depths of Dasein” (p. 131 / GA 197–98 / pdf 77).

Chapter Four (§§29–36). The third form: profound boredom — *es ist einem langweilig*

pp. 132–159 / GA 200–239 / pdf 78–91

The impersonal grammar and the overpowering

The third form bores “whenever we silently know, that *it is boring for one*” (p. 134 / GA 203 / pdf 79). The “it” is the impersonal of *es regnet* — “the title for whatever is indeterminate, unfamiliar” — and the “for one” strips the person: “name, standing, vocation, role, age and fate as mine and yours disappear”; “we become an undifferentiated no one” (p. 135 / GA 203 / pdf 79). No example can be constructed, since this boredom “is not at all relative to a particular situation”; it can strike “out of the blue” — Heidegger’s one non-binding gesture is walking “through the streets of a large city on a Sunday afternoon” (p. 135 / GA 203 / pdf 79).

The pivot is the fate of passing-the-time. In the second form it had shrunk to an evasion; here “we no longer even attain this evasion” — passing-the-time is missing, not by oversight, but because “we have already understood that all passing the time is powerless against this boredom” (p. 135 / GA 204 / pdf 79). To not-permit passing-the-time “means to let this boredom be overpowering” (p. 136 / GA 205 / pdf 80). Where the first form “shouts down” the boredom and the second exhibits “a not wanting to listen,” the third is “a being compelled to listen,” a compelling related to “Dasein’s innermost freedom” (p. 136 / GA 205 / pdf 80).

The telling refusal of beings as a whole

The emptiness is now total and instantaneous: this attunement takes us back “to the point where all and everything appears indifferent to us” — “each and every thing at once,” not spreading “from one thing over onto another like a fire” (pp. 137–38 / GA 207 / pdf 80). Beings as a whole do not disappear; they “show themselves precisely as such in their indifference” (p. 138 / GA 208 / pdf 80). The thesis:

“Being left empty in this third form of boredom is Dasein’s being delivered over to beings’ *telling refusal* [*Versagen*] of themselves as a whole. ... The emptiness is not a hole between things that are filled, but concerns beings as a whole and yet is not the Nothing.” (pp. 139–40 / GA 210 / pdf 81)

The refusal is not mute: “All telling refusal is in itself a telling, i.e., a making manifest” (p. 140 / GA 212 / pdf 82). What beings tell in refusing is the “possibilities of [Dasein’s] doing and acting” that lie unexploited — an announcement that impels Dasein “toward the singular extremity [*Spitze*] of whatever originally makes possible” (p. 144 / GA 216 / pdf 84). Being-held-in-limbo, in this form, is “being impelled toward the originary making-possible of Dasein as such.”

The temporal core: entrancement (Gebanntheit) and the moment of vision (Augenblick)

In this form “looking at the clock ... loses all meaning” — one “feels timeless ... removed from the flow of time” (p. 142 / GA 213 / pdf 83) — and yet the analysis here reaches deepest into time. Beings can refuse them-

selves *as a whole* only insofar as they are “enveloped by the single yet simultaneously threefold horizon of time” — present, having-been, and future in “their unarticulated unity” (p. 145 / GA 219 / pdf 85). What entrances is this horizon itself: “Time entrances [*bannt*] Dasein ... the time which in each case Dasein itself as a whole is” (p. 147 / GA 222 / pdf 84). This *Gebanntheit* is “the temporal character of being-left-empty”; the boredom “can take hold of us in an instant like a flash of lightning,” and precisely in that instant “the whole expanse of the entire time of Dasein is there” (p. 148 / GA 222 / pdf 85).

What the entrancing time simultaneously announces and refuses is Dasein’s ownmost possibility — freedom as self-liberation, which happens “only if Dasein resolutely discloses itself to itself” in resolving “for action here and now”:

“This resolute self-disclosure is the moment of vision [*Augenblick*] ... nothing other than the look of resolute disclosedness [*Blick der Entschlossenheit*] ... in which the full situation of an action opens itself and keeps itself open.” (p. 149 / GA 224 / pdf 87)

The entranced whole-time “announces and tells of itself as that which is to be ruptured and can be ruptured solely in the moment of vision” (p. 150 / GA 224 / pdf 87) — a concept Heidegger credits to Kierkegaard as “really comprehended for the first time in philosophy” (p. 150 / GA 225 / pdf 87), cross-referring to *Being and Time* §65. Only now does the word *Langeweile* receive its essential sense: “In boredom, the while [*Weile*] becomes long [*lang*]” — and “what is at issue is not the time of the clock or chronology, but the lengthening or shortening of *time proper*” (p. 152 / GA 229 / pdf 88). The lengthening “is the expansion of the temporal horizon,” which does not liberate but oppresses “with its expanse” (p. 153 / GA 229 / pdf 88); the shortness that vanishes is “the sharpness and extremity of a moment of vision pertaining to action,” which even in vanishing “still presses itself upon us as that which is properly and tellingly refused” (p. 153 / GA 229 / pdf 88).

The summary definition, the inverted order of the forms, and the suppression

The formal result (§34), offered “as a more incisive directive for interpretation,” not a thesis to take home:

“Boredom is the entrancement of the temporal horizon, an entrancement which lets the moment of vision belonging to temporality vanish. In thus letting it vanish, boredom impels entranced Dasein ... into the moment of vision as the properly authentic possibility of its existence.” (p. 153 / GA 230 / pdf 88)

Two consequences matter for any application. First, the genetic order of the forms is *inverted*: it is not that first-form boredom deepens into the third; rather “the first form precisely holds the others down and keeps them at bay” and “the third form is the condition of the possibility of the first and thereby also of the second” — “only because this constant possibility — the ‘it is boring for one’ — lurks in the ground of Dasein can man be bored ... by the things and people around him” (pp. 156–57 / GA 235 / pdf 90). The forms are “fluid,” with “manifold intermediate forms,” “according to the depth which man grants his own Dasein.” Second, what properly bores in every form is concealed from everyday consciousness: “What is boring is neither beings nor things as such ... but temporality as such” — and because temporality grounds subjectivity, “the legitimate illusion can arise that things are boring, and that it is people themselves who are bored” (p. 158 / GA 236 / pdf 90). §36 adds the polemical coda: the ordinary morality that finds boredom “disturbing, unpleasant, and unbearable,” a “sign of shallowness” to be dispelled by setting oneself “a proper task,” *suppresses* profound boredom, keeping it “within the field of the busy activity of Dasein in its superficiality” (pp.

158–59 / GA 236–38 / pdf 90–91) — so that “a certain conception of feelings ... is not as harmless as we think” (p. 159 / GA 238 / pdf 91).

Chapter Five (§§37–38). Which profound boredom? The absence of oppressiveness

pp. 160–168 / GA 240–49 / pdf 92–96

The formal analysis now turns onto a determinate Dasein — our own. The demand is “not to counteract” profound boredom, which is “neither passivity nor activity” but “Dasein’s keeping to itself, which is a waiting” directed toward “an essential questioning of Dasein itself” (p. 161 / GA 240–42 / pdf 92). The question: “Has man in the end become boring to himself?” (p. 161 / GA 240–42 / pdf 92) — asked not of this or that bored person, but of “the Da-sein in contemporary man as such” (p. 162 / GA 242–43 / pdf 93).

The test of the candidate emptiness is a diagnostic tour de force. Everywhere there are needs — “disruptions, confusion, crises, catastrophes,” social misery, the powerlessness of science, the groundlessness of philosophy — and everywhere programs, parties, and circles organized against them (pp. 162–63 / GA 242–44 / pdf 93). But this “bustling self-defense against these needs precisely does not allow any need *as a whole* to emerge” (p. 163 / GA 243–44 / pdf 93). The emptiness sought is therefore not any particular lack:

“What oppresses us most profoundly and in a concealed manner is ... the very *absence of any essential oppressiveness* [*Bedrängnis*] in our Dasein as a whole. ... The mystery [*Geheimnis*] is lacking in our Da-sein.” (p. 164 / GA 244–46 / pdf 94)

The absence of oppressiveness is attested precisely “by the very activities with which we busy ourselves,” in which there is “a universal smug contentment in not being endangered” (p. 164 / GA 244–46 / pdf 94) — busyness as the disguise of the emptiness, the §38 macro-analogue of the dinner party’s occupied surface. What this refusal simultaneously announces is “the most extreme demand [*Zumutung*] ... that Dasein as such is demanded of man, that it is given to him — to be there” (p. 165 / GA 246–47 / pdf 94). And the methodological constraint returns with full force at the end: we “cannot ever objectively assert or ascertain” this profound boredom “as though it were a matter of fact”; we “can only ask” whether contemporary Dasein, in its very haste to react — a haste it “confuses with the resolute disclosedness of the moment of vision” — acts counter to the possibility of this boredom arising (p. 166 / GA 247–48 / pdf 95).

§39. The hinge: world, individuation, finitude — and time as their root

pp. 169–175 / GA 252–60 / pdf 96–99

Part Two (“What Is World?”) does not change the subject; its questions are “nothing other than an accentuation of the possibility of that fundamental attunement” (p. 171 / GA 254–56 / pdf 97). The derivation is compact. The expanse of the “as a whole” that presses in upon us in profound boredom receives its name: “we shall designate the expanse of this ‘as a whole’, which manifests itself in profound boredom, as world” (p. 169 / GA 252–53 / pdf 96). The moment of vision, “always singular and unique,” names individuation; and the necessity that the expanse be *ruptured* by the moment of vision names finitude — “is it not the finitude of Dasein that resonates in the fundamental attunement of profound boredom?” (p. 169 / GA 253–54 / pdf 96). All three reach back into one root: “profound boredom, and boredom as such, is rooted in the temporality of Dasein,” and “the question concerning the essence of time is the origin of all the questions of metaphysics” (p.

171 / GA 254–56 / pdf 97) — the question of being: *Being and Time* (p. 172 / GA 254–56 / pdf 97). §§40–41 then fix the manner of questioning — philosophy “can only lead us to the brink and always remains something penultimate” (p. 173 / GA 256–57 / pdf 98) — and defend the questions against the two forces that level them down, tradition and “sound common sense” (p. 175 / GA 259–60 / pdf 99).

Part III. The Three Forms in Synopsis

	First form <i>Gelangweiltwerden von...</i>	Second form <i>Sichlangweilen bei...</i>	Third form <i>es ist einem langweilig</i>
Paradigm	the provincial train station, four hours to the next train	the agreeable evening invitation	no example possible; “out of the blue”
Culprit	determinate (this station, this wait)	none determinable — “I know not what”; arises from Dasein itself	beings as a whole in their telling refusal
Being left empty	things at hand offer nothing; refusal of the situation	self-forming emptiness; the proper self left behind	delivered over to the telling refusal of beings as a whole
Being held in limbo	by time as it drags over a bounded interval	set in place by standing time, the single stretched “now”	impelled toward the extremity of what makes Dasein possible (the <i>Augenblick</i>)
<i>Zeitvertreib</i>	conspicuous, restless: pacing, counting, clock-watching; the watch-glance as “helpless gesture”	inconspicuous and total: the entire comportment, the whole evening itself	no longer permitted; powerless; being compelled to listen
Surface vs. depth	aligned — visibly restless	divergent — occupied surface, hollow depth; boredom denied, recognized only afterward	aligned — visibly withdrawn, still
Relation to clock-time	time drags; interval finite and counted	no clock-glances, yet the “during” stands and stretches	the clock loses all meaning; one “feels timeless”; the while lengthens
Depth	shallowest — situation-bound	deeper — less situation-bound; from Dasein	deepest — condition of possibility of the other two

Sources: §§19–36 as cited above; seven-point comparison at pp. 130–31 / GA 195–98 / pdf 77; inverted order of the forms at pp. 156–57 / GA 235 / pdf 90.

Part IV. The Boredom Analysis as an Interpretive Instrument for VLE Engagement Research

Provenance. Everything in Part IV that maps Heidegger onto data is projected (anticipatory-application): the three-form architecture is Heidegger's; the findings are the King-Salvo teams', as published; every correspondence between them is a hypothesis of this report, offered for testing, not as an established result of either source.

IV.1 The empirical record

Three studies of the same instructional stimulus family — a 360° clinical-immersion environment for biomedical-engineering education — accumulate, across three instruments, a pattern their shared boredom model cannot represent.

Physiological pilot (King, Feeney, Tang, Das & Salvo, ASEE 2023; N = 3). Three 17-minute videos: boring control (a 1989 word-processor tutorial), exciting control, and the 360° clinical-immersion surgery. Boredom is operationalized on the Fahlman definition — “the aversive experience of having an unfulfilled desire to be engaged in satisfying activity” — with default-mode-network activity (alpha/theta EEG) as marker. Findings: the clinical video's EEG *more closely resembled the boring control* than the exciting one [suggestive only: one clean EEG record of three]; self-reported engagement was high [clean]; and all three subjects felt the 17-minute clinical video as *longer* than its actual length, one by 25–30 minutes [clean].

Eye-tracking study (King, Lo, Das & Salvo, ASEE 2024; N = 12 + 4 webcam). Same videos; presentation reordered because the boring-first ordering “increased levels of exhaustion” in subsequent conditions — itself a boredom-relevant datum (carryover/depletion). Findings: gaze-variance for the clinical video was statistically distinct from the boring control and *resembled the engaging video* (ANOVA, $p = 0.0004$); and the team drew its own two-boredoms distinction: high-arousal boredom, in which the bored viewer “look[s] around the screen trying to find something to attend to” (high gaze-variance), versus low-arousal boredom, a “zombie stare” with collapsed gaze-variance, observed in two subjects.

Phenomenological evaluation (King & Salvo, *Biomedical Engineering Education* 2024, 4:381–397; N ≈ 20–22). Four formats of the same operating-room footage rated for presence and educational benefit. Finding of interest: a presence-versus-preference split — 70% felt greater presence in VR, yet 40% judged plain 2D video the most educationally beneficial, citing convenience and physical discomfort; of the loanable VR headsets, “not a single student went there to check one out.” Caveat: this study contains no boredom operationalization and no time-perception probe; its relevance is indirect.

The anomaly, stated in one sentence: *the same stimulus simultaneously reads boring-like on the depth channel (EEG/DMN), engaging-like on the surface channel (gaze), highly engaging on self-report — and dilates felt time*. A bipolar engaged_u bored scale (the instrument all three studies presuppose) must discard at least one of these readings as error.

IV.2 The structural mapping

FCM's three forms are not three intensities of one variable; they are three *structures*, distinguished by (a) whether a determinate culprit is present, (b) whether surface occupation and depth-emptiness diverge, and (c) what becomes of passing-the-time. Mapped onto the teams' own signatures:

FCM form (faithful)	Phenomenal signature (faithful)	Empirical correlate (faithful-empirical)	Status
First — bored <i>by</i> (§§19–23)	restless <i>Zeitvertreib</i> : scanning, fidgeting, clock-watching for something to occupy us	high-arousal boredom: high gaze-variance, “looking around ... to find something to attend to”	projected
Second — bored <i>with</i> (§§24–28)	outwardly occupied, boredom denied; emptiness self-forming; time stands and stretches	the clinical “in-between”: gaze $\approx$ engaged <i>yet</i> EEG $\approx$ boring; engagement affirmed <i>yet</i> 17 min felt as 25–30	projected (keystone)
Third — profound (§§29–36)	<i>Zeitvertreib</i> falls away; stillness; beings withdraw as a whole	low-arousal “zombie stare”: collapsed gaze-variance, search ceased	projected (phenomenology only; see IV.6)

Three observations lift the mapping above loose analogy. (a) The 2024 description of high-arousal boredom is not merely *like Zeitvertreib*; it is *Zeitvertreib* operationalized. Heidegger's first-form subject paces the platform and checks the watch (p. 96–97 / GA 146–47 / pdf 60–61) for exactly the reason the bored viewer scans the screen: to drive off an emptiness by manufacturing occupation. Gaze-variance is thereby a candidate *physiological signature of passing-the-time* — and the watch-glance analysis adds a refinement: off-task check-behaviors index not boredom's presence but its counter-move's *failure*, a graded marker. (b) The “zombie stare” matches the third form's phenomenology precisely — the ceasing of search, the stillness, the collapse of the will-to-occupy (“all passing the time is powerless,” p. 135 / GA 204 / pdf 79) — while stopping short of its metaphysical claim. (c) The second form is the only one in which surface and depth structurally come apart: the dinner-party guest is “totally involved” all evening and would deny boredom if asked, yet *was* bored. That structural fact is the payload, developed next.

IV.3 The keystone: the cross-instrument contradiction *is* the second form

The apparent contradiction — 2023 EEG says the clinical stimulus is boring-like, 2024 gaze says it is engaging-like — reads as a measurement flaw only if boredom is a single-channel quantity. FCM's second form *predicts the divergence*. Being-bored-*with* is precisely the condition in which outward comportment remains occupied — indeed, in which “our entire comportment and behaviour ... is our passing the time” (p. 112 / GA 169–70 / pdf 68) — while the underlying attunement is a self-forming emptiness (p. 120 / GA 180–82 / pdf 72). Map the channels:

^cGaze / outward comportment = the surface. In the second form it looks engaged — eyes tracking the procedure, low search-variance. Matches 2024.

^cEEG/DMN = a proxy for the underlying attunement. In the second form it is hollow — boring-like. Matches 2023.

^cSelf-report = caught between. Subjects say “engaged” (reading their own surface, like the guest who denies boredom) yet report dilated, dragging time (the depth leaking through). Matches both.

On this reading the two studies do not disagree about *how bored* the clinical stimulus is; they measure different structural layers of a single second-form episode. The contradiction dissolves, and in dissolving yields a method: *the second form is detectable only as the disagreement of a surface channel and a depth channel — never from either alone*, and never from a bipolar scale, which forces the layers into one number. The time-dilation findings independently corroborate the reading: the second form’s limbo is standing time, the “single stretched now” of total presence (p. 125 / GA 188–89 / pdf 75) — so FCM predicts that precisely the *absorbed* viewer, given over wholly to the presented procedure, will report the while lengthening *without* clock-watching behavior. That is what the 2023 subjects did.

The 2024 phenomenological study supplies a weak converging analog in a third register: the presence-versus-preference split — the medium *occupies* the viewer (70% greater presence) while the educational depth is judged hollow (40% prefer plain 2D) — is a second-form-shaped pattern in first-person report. It bears no evidential weight (no boredom or time measure), but it adds the lived-experience leg to a triangulation whose other two legs are physiological (EEG) and behavioral (gaze).

IV.4 What FCM says *to* the instruments: three methodological warnings

(1) Ascertaining is not awakening. The founding claim of §16 — that objectifying an attunement “precisely destroy[s], or at least ... weaken[s] and alter[s]” it (p. 62 / GA 93–94 / pdf 43), and that a fundamental attunement can never be “registered ... as though it were a matter of fact” (p. 166 / GA 247–48 / pdf 95) — does not forbid measurement, but it relocates what measurement can deliver: physiological correlates of an attunement, never the attunement’s disclosure itself. Null and contradictory single-channel readings are what the frame *predicts*, not failures of technique. Practically: treat instruments as reading *comportment* (the *Zeitvertreib* layer, where boredom shows itself “undisguised,” p. 91 / GA 136–38 / pdf 58) rather than the mood as an inner object — and treat self-report with the §24 caution that the second form’s subject *sincerely denies* being bored while bored.

(2) Do not infer depth from any single surface index. §28’s inversion — busy “having no time” may be the greater lostness; depth “can be read off only from the specific constitution of boredom itself in each case” (p. 130 / GA 195–97 / pdf 77) — is a direct caution against arousal-threshold classifiers and against reading fast, active gaze as engagement. The §38 figure of “bustling self-defense” that conceals the emptiness (p. 163–64 / GA 243–46 / pdf 93–94) is the same warning at cultural scale.

(3) Beware the instrument that levels. A bipolar engaged_u bored axis performs exactly the flattening §41 condemns — it “levels down” a structured, three-form phenomenon into one scalar and thereby “robs the questioning of its edge” (p. 175 / GA 259–60 / pdf 99). And the ordinary-morality coda of §36 warns that a research program which codes boredom purely as an aversive state to be engineered away will *systematically under-detect* the deepest, stillest, low-arousal form (p. 159 / GA 238 / pdf 91) — the very “zombie stare” cases that appeared in only two subjects and could easily be discarded as inattention artifacts.

IV.5 Design implications for the next VLE study

1. Instrument the divergence, not the level. Compute a per-epoch surface–depth disagreement index — (gaze-engagement signature) ⁽¹⁾ (DMN/alpha depth signature). Prediction: clinical-immersion content maximizes this index even where each channel alone is ambiguous. This operationalizes IV.3.
2. Add a felt-duration probe. Retrospective duration ratio or periodic “how long has this felt?” Time dilation is the cleanest signal already in the data and the most direct measure of *Hingehaltenheit* / the lengthening while (§§32–33); FCM’s decoupling of drag from clock-length (“not because the progress of time is slow, but because it is *too* slow,” p. 97 / GA 146–47 / pdf 61) is what lets felt duration dissociate from every arousal measure.
3. Replace the bipolar scale with a three-state classifier. Targets: *first form* = high-arousal search (high gaze-variance, intact time-sense, off-task check-behaviors); *second form* = divergent-occupied (surface $\approx$ engaged, depth $\approx$ empty, time dilated); *third form* = low-arousal withdrawn (collapsed variance, search ceased). A discriminant model (e.g., the team’s planned Fisher’s LDA) should be fit to these three structured classes, not to one boredom axis.
4. Treat gaze-variance as the *Zeitvertreib* channel. High variance = active passing-the-time (form I); collapse = its cessation (form III); validate against a behavioral search measure. Repeated off-task glances should be scored as the “helpless gesture” of failing *Zeitvertreib* — a graded index, not binary distraction.
5. Expect nothing for the *Augenblick*. The moment of vision is what the entranced horizon *excludes* (p. 153 / GA 229 / pdf 88); it can register, at most, as the absence of a signal — a refused call to action, not a state. Design for its negative space (e.g., moments where learners could act and do not), not for a detector.
6. Model the carryover. The 2024 order-effect (boring-first, exhaustion) is data: boredom depletes. FCM treats boredom as disclosive, not as depleting, and leaves the aftermath untheorized — an open problem the empirical program is positioned to address. Add washout intervals and measure after-effects explicitly.

IV.6 A category caution

Heidegger’s profound boredom is a *Grundstimmung* that discloses beings as a whole and opens the questions of world, individuation, and finitude (§39). A 17-minute instructional video does not induce that, and this report does not claim it does. What transfers is FCM’s structural grammar — the three-form architecture, the two structural moments, the surface/depth divergence, *Zeitvertreib* and its fate, the temporal stretch — as a heuristic for classifying experiential episodes. The first/second-form distinction transfers cleanly, because it concerns structure, not cosmic scope. “Third form” transfers as *phenomenology* (stillness, ceased search, felt timelessness) under an explicit analogy, not as the claim that students underwent metaphysical disclosure. Stated plainly so that any downstream chapter can cite the limit rather than trip over it. One further honesty: by §16’s own lights, no instrument ascertains an attunement — the empirical program measures the comportmental and physiological *shadows* of boredom’s forms, which is both all it can do and, on this report’s argument, enough to discriminate the forms.

IV.7 Faithful / projected ledger

Claim	Layer	Status / reliability
Three forms; two structural moments; surface/depth divergence unique to the second form	faithful-Heidegger	§§19–36, cited above
Third form is condition of possibility of the first two; forms are fluid with intermediates	faithful-Heidegger	pp. 156–57 / GA 235 / pdf 90
High- vs. low-arousal (“zombie stare”) boredom distinguished by gaze-variance	faithful-em-pirical	ASEE 2024, N=12; the authors’ own observation
Clinical EEG $\approx$ boring control	faithful-em-pirical	ASEE 2023; suggestive only (one clean record)
Clinical gaze-variance $\approx$ engaging ($p=0.0004$)	faithful-em-pirical	ASEE 2024; significant
Time dilation on the clinical stimulus (all subjects)	faithful-em-pirical	ASEE 2023; clean self-report
Presence _r yet 2D judged most beneficial	faithful-em-pirical	BME Education 2024; no boredom/time measure
first _u high-arousal; second _u in-between; third _u zombie-stare	projected	this report’s hypothesis
The EEG/gaze contradiction = a second-form surface/depth split	projected	keystone; testable via IV.5.1
Presence/preference split = second-form analog	projected	weak; converging analogy only

Lean-on / hold-back. Lean on: the N = 12 gaze data, the clean time-dilation self-reports, the teams’ own high/low-arousal distinction. Hold back: the 2023 EEG (corroborating, not load-bearing) and the phenomenological split (analogy only). The keystone claim survives even if the EEG is discounted entirely: the second-form divergence then rests on *self-reported time-dilation versus gaze-engagement* as its two disagreeing channels.

Connections to *Being and Time* (1927)

^cAttunement, *Befindlichkeit* (BT §29): §17’s theses — attunement as the fundamental way of Dasein’s being, always-already-attunedness, disclosure prior to cognition — re-run and radicalize BT’s account of disposedness; the “most powerful are least noticed” principle extends BT’s claim that mood discloses being-in-the-world as a whole.

^cThe *Augenblick* (BT §§65, 68): Heidegger cross-refers explicitly (p. 150 / GA 225 / pdf 87), crediting Kierkegaard and calling BT’s treatment “an external aid” in which the problem was “merely grasped in

its nucleus” — the boredom analysis is thus offered as the *phenomenal access* to the temporality BT approached structurally.

°Profound boredom beside anxiety (BT §40): FCM installs a second fundamental attunement alongside *Angst*. Both disclose beings as a whole through withdrawal; but where anxiety individualizes before the nothing, profound boredom’s telling refusal announces unexploited possibility — disclosure in the key of indifference rather than uncanniness.

°Standing time and inauthentic presence: the second form’s “making-present” that seals off having-been and future (p. 125 / GA 188–89 / pdf 75) is the mood-side elaboration of BT’s inauthentic temporality (awaiting-forgetting-making-present, BT §68) — the dinner party is *Verfallenheit* rendered as felt time.

°From fundamental ontology to metontology: §39’s rooting of world, finitude, and individuation in the essence of time carries BT’s program forward into the comparative examination (stone–animal–man) of Part Two — the attunement analysis is the bridge between the two projects.

Tensions Worth Flagging

1. Awakening vs. any empirical program. If objectification “destroys, or at least weakens and alters” an attunement (p. 62 / GA 93–94 / pdf 43), then every instrumented protocol — EEG cap, eye tracker, questionnaire — stands under a principled suspicion, and self-report instruments doubly so (§24’s guest sincerely denies the boredom he is in). The application in Part IV threads this needle by measuring *comportment* (the *Zeitvertreib* layer) rather than claiming to ascertain the attunement; but the tension is real and should be cited, not hidden, in any methodology chapter that leans on this material.
 2. Scale-transfer. Heidegger’s second and third forms are analyzed on occasions (an evening, a Sunday afternoon) but ultimately concern the depth “which man grants his own Dasein” (p. 157 / GA 235 / pdf 90) — and §38’s particular profound boredom is epochal, not episodic. Applying the form-structures to 17-minute stimulus episodes presupposes that the *structural grammar* scales down even though the *metaphysical scope* does not. IV.6 states this as an explicit analogy; the presupposition itself remains philosophically undischarged.
 3. Disclosive vs. depleting. FCM treats boredom as disclosure and never as depletion, yet the 2024 order-effect (boring-first exhausts subsequent conditions) shows boredom has an aftermath. Where does the dragging while *go* when the episode ends? Heidegger’s framework has no answer; the empirical program does have data. This is the one place the traffic across the bridge plausibly runs from the lab toward the philosophy.
 4. The inverted order cuts both ways. If the third form is the condition of possibility of the first two (p. 157 / GA 235 / pdf 90), then classificatory schemes that treat the forms as exclusive states (including IV.5’s three-state classifier) simplify a nested structure into a partition. The classifier should be read as sorting *dominant signatures*, not as denying that the deeper form “lurks in the ground” of every shallower one.
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Source Inventory

Source	Path
Primary text (book pp. 59–175; PDF pp. 41–99, 2-up scan; offset book = 2pdf ⁽¹⁾ 24, verified)	corpus/metaphysics/Heidegger, Martin - The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics.pdf
Index entry — boredom spine units (awakening; first, second, third forms; particular profound; Part Two hinge)	corpus/index/Heidegger - The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics/units/fcm-03...08
Index entry — synthesis layer (attunement manual; King–Salvo bridge; page–offset verification; ontology)	corpus/index/Heidegger - The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics/_synthesis/
Empirical digests (ASEE 2023 physiological; ASEE 2024 eye-tracking; BME Education 2024 phenomenological)	corpus/index/Heidegger - The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics/bridge-sources/
Empirical primary sources	corpus/Virtual Learning Environments/King, Christine and Dalton Salvo - *.pdf

Translation cited: Martin Heidegger, *The Fundamental Concepts of Metaphysics: World, Finitude, Solitude*, trans. William McNeill and Nicholas Walker (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1995); German pagination from *Die Grundbegriffe der Metaphysik: Welt—Endlichkeit—Einsamkeit*, Gesamtausgabe 29/30 (Frankfurt a.M.: Klostermann), as printed in the translation’s running heads. Empirical sources: King, Feeney, Tang, Das & Salvo, ASEE 2023 (#37129); King, Lo, Das & Salvo, ASEE 2024 (#44685); King & Salvo, *Biomedical Engineering Education* 4 (2024): 381–397.